

5.3 Encoding Restraint

Restraint is the presence of emotion under compression. The feeling is there, actively managed, actively contained. Encode the management, the effort, and the specific linguistic markers that show the lid being held down.

5.3.1 Compression Worksheet (Grumpy Hero Restraint)

Purpose: Encode restraint for a character who compresses large emotions into small verbal containers. The speech slows down under pressure.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Component	Your Entry
The ratio rule (felt vs. expressed):	[E.G., "The felt emotion is two levels larger than the expressed. If the character feels devastation, he expresses irritation. If he feels tenderness, he expresses mild inconvenience."]
The rhythmic marker (how compression appears in pacing):	[E.G., "The sentence arrives one beat later than natural speech. The character selects each word from a restricted menu."]
The vocabulary boundary (what words are forbidden):	[E.G., "No words that directly name the feeling. The character says 'it's fine' when the feeling is not fine."]

5.3.2 Overcompensation Worksheet (Sunshine Heroine Restraint)

Purpose: Encode restraint for a character who covers dark emotions with brightness. The speech speeds up under pressure.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Component	Your Entry
The inverse ratio rule (felt vs. expressed):	[E.G., "The expressed emotion is two levels brighter than the felt. If the character feels abandonment terror, she expresses breezy enthusiasm. If she feels hurt, she expresses playful teasing."]

Component	Your Entry
The pacing marker (how overcompensation appears in speed):	[E.G., "Sentences arrive faster than natural speech. The character fills space before the feeling can surface. Intensifiers multiply."]
The verbal tells (specific phrases that signal the cover):	[E.G., "'Oh my gosh, that's so funny!' when the feeling is not funny. 'No, seriously, I'm totally fine!' when the fineness is the lie."]

5.3.3 Restraint Encoding Quality Check

Read your restraint constraint statement and verify each box before finalizing.

- ☐ The statement names a felt emotion (something is being managed).
- ☐ The statement names an expressed emotion (something is being shown instead).
- ☐ The statement includes at least one rhythmic or pacing marker (the management is visible in the speed or timing of the speech).
- ☐ The statement includes at least one vocabulary or word-choice boundary (the management is visible in what the character says or refuses to say).
- ☐ You could read this statement to a stranger and they could produce dialogue where the tension is audible without being told "the character is restraining."
- ☐ The statement does NOT contain the phrase "does not show emotion" or "hides all feeling" or "remains completely stoic."

When even one of the first five boxes is unchecked, your encoding is incomplete. When the sixth box is checked, your encoding captures absence, and it does not capture management. Rewrite that part by naming the feeling, naming the effort, and naming the language markers that show the lid being held down.